A FACT SHEET FOR MONTANANS WHO WANT A REAL CHECK ON TRUMP

So you don't want a Trump Republican as your senator.

Here's what a vote for Seth Bodnar can — and can't — deliver.

Seth Bodnar says plenty that anti-Trump Montanans want to hear. He calls the tariffs "nonsensical."[3] He has condemned a "masked, untrained, unaccountable paramilitary force" in our cities.[4] But in the U.S. Senate, **criticism is not a check on power.** Power comes from a majority, a committee seat, and a gavel. Bodnar has pledged away the one thing that gets you all three.

THE PLEDGE Bodnar has pledged **not to caucus with either party**.[1] His biggest outside backer, the Manchin-founded Independent Leadership Council's PAC, has reported about **$1.8 million** supporting him. It only backs candidates who make that pledge.[2]

What you're counting on vs. what a no-caucus senator can deliver

WHAT ANTI-TRUMP VOTERS WANT	BODNAR	WHY
Take the Senate majority away from Trump's party	❌ No	A senator who won't join the Democratic caucus doesn't count toward a Democratic majority. In 2001, a single senator, Jim Jeffords, flipped control of the entire Senate. He could only do it because he joined a caucus.[5]
Replace Trump-aligned leadership and control what gets a vote	❌ No	The majority leader is chosen by the majority party's caucus, and the majority leader decides what reaches the floor. Outside every caucus, Bodnar gets no vote on who leads.
Investigate and subpoena the administration	❌ No	Investigations and subpoenas are run by committee chairs. Chairs come from the majority caucus.
Use the power of the purse to stop unlawful actions	❌ No	Funding limits and "no money for X" provisions are written in the Appropriations Committee. Seats on it are handed out through the party caucuses.
Rein in ICE abuses	⚠️ Words only	He says he'd "legislate accountability."[4] But legislation is written in committee, and he'd have no committee seat to write it from.
Convict Trump if the House impeaches	⚠️ Not committed	The House impeaches, then the Senate holds the trial; conviction takes 67 votes.[12] We found no public commitment from Bodnar to vote to convict.
Vote yes or no on bills and nominees	✅ Yes	Every senator gets a vote. This is the part he *can* do. But it comes at the very end of the process, and only on what the majority chooses to bring up.

❌ = structurally out of reach without a caucus · ⚠️ = said but no commitment or no means to deliver · ✅ = within reach. Numbers refer to sources on page 3.

Where bills actually live or die

19,315	96%	4%
bills and resolutions introduced in the last full Congress (2023–24)	never got a vote in either chamber	(685) ever got a vote, the only stage where a senator's "one vote" counts[6]

A bill's path, and where Bodnar gets a say

1	✅	**Introduce a bill** Any senator can. Nearly all go nowhere.
2	❌	**Get a hearing and a committee vote** Committee members decide which bills move. Seats come through the party caucuses.
3	❌	**Write the actual language and add Montana's priorities** Done in committee "markups." No seat, no amendments, nothing to trade.
4	❌	**Get scheduled for a floor vote** The majority leader decides, and the majority caucus picks the leader.
5	❌	**Negotiate the final deal** Committee leaders write the final text behind closed doors (see Sheehy below).
6	✅	**Vote yes or no** One vote of 100, on a bill he had no hand in choosing or shaping.

Results come from seats at the table (whatever you think of the senator)

CHAIR, SENATE VETERANS' AFFAIRS

Tester: PACT Act (2022)

The biggest expansion of care for toxic-exposed veterans in decades. It passed the Senate 86–11.[7]

CHAIR, DEFENSE APPROPRIATIONS SUBCOMMITTEE

Tester: Malmstrom and the Montana Guard

A gavel over nearly all defense spending meant real clout for Great Falls.[8]

MEMBER, HOUSE APPROPRIATIONS

Zinke: about $35M for western Montana (FY2026)

Including $10M for the Noxon Bridge and $10M for Seeley Lake's wastewater plant.[9]

MEMBER, SENATE ARMED SERVICES

Sheehy: even a seat isn't always enough

His bipartisan military right-to-repair language with Sen. Warren was written in committee and passed both chambers. Then committee leaders stripped it from the final bill. Without a seat, you don't even get that far.[10]

The last time a senator tried this

In 1953, Oregon's Wayne Morse left the Republican Party and refused to join either side. He was **stripped of his seats on Armed Services and Labor** and left with the low-profile D.C. and Public Works committees, the seats party leaders chose to give him. When he forced a floor vote to get his seats back, **7 senators** backed him. He got his pick of committees back in 1955, **only after joining the Democrats.**[11]

Bodnar says he can "negotiate for committee positions like any other senator."[1] No senator has managed it since.[13]

"But couldn't he be the swing vote?" Swing votes are powerful because they can be traded. Jeffords traded his for a Democratic majority. Bodnar has promised never to make that trade, so the leverage is gone before he's sworn in.

The bottom line

Stopping Trump's agenda takes more than a "no" at the finish line. It takes a majority, a committee seat, and a gavel.

Ask Seth Bodnar: if your vote decides the Senate majority, will you give it to the party that will hold Trump accountable? So far, his pledge says no.

Numbered sources are listed on the next page.

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Sources and notes

1. Daily Montanan, "Bodnar announces independent campaign for U.S. Senate," Mar. 4, 2026; Hungry Horse News, "Bodnar stumps in Kalispell, commits to independence," Jul. 22, 2026; Newsweek, "Inside Seth Bodnar's Montana Senate Race...," 2026.
2. Montana Public Radio, "Interest group money rolls in to Montana's congressional races," Sep. 18, 2026; CNN, "Joe Manchin reenters the political orbit with a new independent experiment," Jul. 24, 2026.
3. KTVQ/KXLF, "Montana U.S. Senate hopeful Seth Bodnar talks tariffs, war and running without a party," 2026.
4. Daily Montanan, "Debate between US Senate candidates tips scales for audience members," Sep. 22, 2026.
5. U.S. Senate Historical Office, "Tom Daschle" (senate.gov); PBS NewsHour, Jeffords coverage, May 23–24, 2001.
6. GovTrack.us, "Historical Statistics about Legislation in the U.S. Congress," 118th Congress (2023–24). "Got a vote" means a significant vote in either chamber; counts include resolutions.
7. Senate Veterans' Affairs Committee press releases, June and August 2022 (veterans.senate.gov).
8. Defense News, "Sen. Jon Tester takes defense appropriations gavel," Feb. 12, 2021.
9. Office of Rep. Ryan Zinke press releases, Jan. 22 and Feb. 3, 2026 (zinke.house.gov).
10. Sen. Warren press release, "Warren, Sheehy Blast Removal of Right to Repair from NDAA," Dec. 2025 (warren.senate.gov); Federal News Network, "Congress quietly strips right-to-repair provisions from 2026 NDAA," Dec. 2025.
11. U.S. Senate Historical Office, "Independent Fights" and "Wayne Morse" (senate.gov).
12. U.S. Constitution, Art. I, §2, cl. 5 and §3, cl. 6.
13. MSU Exponent, "Bodnar's unconventional Senate campaign takes shape, questions linger about his chances," 2026.

Notes on wording

- **"Impeach" vs. "convict."** The House impeaches; the Senate tries the case. A senator's role is the vote to convict, which takes two-thirds of senators present.
- **Committee seats.** No Senate rule bars a non-caucusing senator from committees. But seats are allocated through the two party conferences. The only modern attempt (Morse, 1953) ended with him losing his major committees.
- **Bill statistics.** Counts vary by source and definition. We use GovTrack's full-Congress figures for 2023–24, which include resolutions. Roughly 1–2% of bills became law.
- **Impeachment position.** "No public commitment found" reflects a review of news coverage and candidate statements through Oct. 11, 2026. If Bodnar commits publicly, this row should be updated.

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